

Session 20: New Heart, New Spirit

Key Takeaways

- Defiling or profaning something is to take something holy and treat it as though it is common.
- Israel's violence and injustice have profaned God's holy name, making it appear to the nations that Yahweh is unjust and powerless.
- God will restore Israel and give the people a new heart and his own Spirit. By doing this, he will demonstrate his character to the world.
- God accomplishes his purposes by enabling his human partners to participate in God's own life by his Spirit.

Translation and Literary Design of Ezekiel 36:16-38

¹⁶ Then the word of Yahweh came to me saying,
¹⁷ "Son of a human,
the house of Israel was living in their own land,
and they made it **impure** through their ways and their deeds;
like the **impurity** of **menstrual blood**, so their ways were before me,
¹⁸ and I poured out on them my hot-anger,
because of the **blood** which they had spilled on the land,
and because they had made it **impure** with their dung-balls.
¹⁹ And I scattered them among **the nations**,
and they were dispersed throughout **the lands**.
According to their ways and their deeds I judged them.

²⁰ "And they went to the nations where they went,
and they **profaned** **my** **holy** **name**,
because it was said of them,
'These are the people of Yahweh,
yet they have come out of his land.'
²¹ But I had concern for **my** **holy** **name**,
which the house of Israel had **profaned**
among the nations where they went.

22 Therefore say to the house of Israel,
'Thus says Yahweh Elohim,
"It is not for your sake, O house of Israel, that I am about to act,
but for the sake of my holy name which you have profaned
among the nations where you went.
23 I will demonstrate the holiness of my great name,
which has been profaned among the nations,
which you have profaned in their midst,
and the nations will know that I am Yahweh,"
declares Yahweh Elohim,
"when I demonstrate myself as holy among you in their eyes.

24 And I will take you from the nations,
and I will gather you from all the lands,
and I will bring you into your own land.

25 And I will sprinkle pure water on you,
and you will be purified from all your impurities,
and I will purify you from all your idols,

26 and I will give you a new heart,
and a new spirit I will put within you,
and I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh,
and I will give you a heart of flesh.

27 and my Spirit I will put within you,
and I will make it so that you will walk in my statutes,
and you will keep and do what I decide,
28 you will live in the land that I gave to your fathers,
and you will be my people,
and I will be your Elohim.

29 And I will rescue you from all your impurities,
and I will call for the grain and multiply it,
and I will not bring a famine on you,
30 and I will multiply the fruit of the tree and the produce of the field,
so that you will not receive again the disgrace of famine among the nations.

31 And you will remember your evil ways and your deeds that were not good,
and you will despise yourselves before your face for your iniquities and your abominations,

32 I am not doing this for your sake,"

declares Yahweh Elohim,
"Let that be known to you!
Be ashamed and humiliated for your ways, O house of Israel!"

33 Thus says Yahweh Elohim,
"On the day that I **purify** you from all your iniquities,
I will cause the cities to **be inhabited** ,
and the **waste places** will **be rebuilt** ,
34 and the **desolate** land will **be worked** ,
instead of being a **desolation** in the eyes of all who pass by,

35 **and they will say** ,
 'This **desolate** land has become like **the garden of Eden** ,
 and the **wasted**, **desolate** and **torn down cities** are fortified and **inhabited** .'
36 **and the nations** that are remaining round about you,
they will know that I, Yahweh,
I have rebuilt the **torn down** places,
I have planted what was **desolate**.
I, Yahweh, have spoken and will do it."

37 Thus says Yahweh Elohim,
"This also I will let the house of Israel ask me to do for them:
I will make them **multiply** like a **flock** of humans,
38 like a **flock** of **holy ones** ,
like a **flock** at Jerusalem during her appointed times,
so will the **wasted cities** **be filled** with **flocks** of humans.
And they will know that I am Yahweh.""

Ezekiel 36:16-38. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Restoration for the Failed Covenant Partners

This is a retelling of the story of Israel's fall into exile, but from Yahweh's perspective and highlighting the effect Israel's exile had on his reputation among the nations.

Yahweh's "holy name" and reputation was "defiled" by Israel's apostasy and exile (Ezek. 36:20-21). The fate of nations was popularly linked to the fate of their national deity (see the same logic from the lips of an Assyrian commander in 2 Kgs. 18:33-35). Israel's exile meant Yahweh was perceived as merely a tribal god who lost to Marduk and couldn't defend his people (remember Moses' appeal to the same logic in Exod. 32:12; Num. 14:16).

Yahweh will restore Israel to "hallow" his name (Ezek. 36:22-24). Restoration from exile will not depend on the quality of Israel's repentance. Rather, it will be purely driven by Yahweh's desire to be known truly among the

nations as the creator and redeemer God of all nations (note Jesus' allusion to this line in the Lord's prayer in [Matt. 6:9](#)).

The restoration is a multifaceted divine response to Israel's fate (themes drawn from [Deut. 30](#)).

- Ezekiel 36:24: restoration to the promised land
- Ezekiel 36:25: ceremonial cleansing from moral impurity (borrowing language from [Num. 19](#), the ceremony of the red heifer)

A New Heart and Spirit

In [Ezekiel 36:26-27](#), God says he will give his people a new heart and spirit. "Heart" (Heb. *lev*) is the center of will and emotion, and "spirit" (Heb. *ruakh*) is the animating life energy, which is then qualified as "my Spirit in you" which will enable Israel to obey the terms of the covenant (from [Lev. 26:3](#); the theme here is entirely drawn from [Deut. 30:1-10](#) and explored later by Paul in [Rom. 7-8](#)).

Ezekiel expresses a theme that echoes in other literature from the period of exile.

Jeremiah 31:18-19 NASB

I have surely heard Ephraim grieving, "You have chastised me, and I was chastised, like an untrained calf; bring me back that I may turn back, for you are the LORD my God. For after I turned back, I repented."

Jeremiah 32:38-40 NASB

They shall be my people, and I will be their God; and I will give them one heart and one way, that they may fear me always, for their own good and for the good of their children after them. I will make an everlasting covenant with them that I will not turn away from them, to do them good; and I will put the fear of me in their hearts so that they will not turn away from me.

Lamentations 5:21 NASB

Restore us to you, O LORD, that we may be restored; Renew our days as of old ...

"God will no longer gamble with Israel as he did in old times, and Israel rebelled against him; in the future—no more experiments! God will put his spirit into them, he will alter their hearts (their minds) and make it impossible for them to be anything but obedient to his rules and his commandments. The declaration abandons all hope that Israel, in her present condition, can achieve the ideals of covenant relationship originally intended by Yahweh. The status quo can be altered only by direct divine intervention."

Greenberg, Moshe (1995). "Three Conceptions of Torah in the Hebrew Bible." [Studies in the Bible and Jewish Thought](#). Jewish Publication Society.

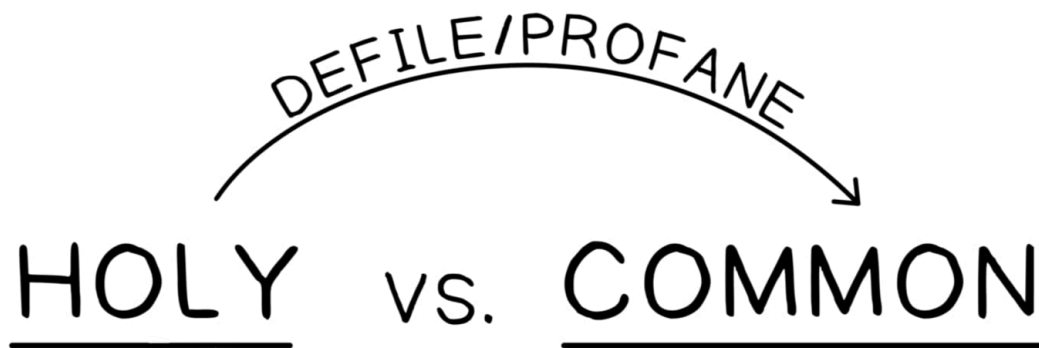
In [36:28-30](#), Ezekiel takes the covenant restoration blessings from [Leviticus 26:42-45](#) and turns them into promises of future hope.

Shame and Hope

While Yahweh has removed the public disgrace of Israel among the nations (36:15 Heb. *kelimmah* = public dishonor), Israel before the exile was unable to experience guilt-shame for its covenant faithlessness (for more on this motif see Jer. 3:3, 6:15, 8:12; Heb. *bosh* and *qut*, same as used in 36:31-32). Paradoxically, Yahweh's salvation will instill a proper moral awareness that can feel healthy guilt for wrongdoing (similar to Paul's self-awareness in 1 Tim. 1:15).

The exiles will return, rebuild, and restore the land to Eden-like conditions, and all for the purpose of the nations paying attention and acknowledging Yahweh (Ezek. 36:33-38).

Holy Versus Common



Holy Vs. Common. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

The Waters and the Spirit

CORRUPTION
DEFILED →

DEATH
WATER

→ PURITY
WHOLENESS

IMPURITY →

→ PURITY

DEATH →

SPIRIT

→ LIFE

The Waters and the Spirit. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Reflection Question

How does God plan to restore the reputation of his name among the nations?